

Technology Adoption Lifecycle

GLOSSARY 01 - SHEET 7 / 8

The sequence of adopter groups through which an innovation diffuses

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The technology adoption lifecycle is the sequence of distinct adopter categories - innovators, early adopters, early majority, late majority and laggards - through which an innovation diffuses over time, distributed approximately normally across a population. Each category adopts for different reasons and responds to different evidence, so a message that persuades one will not persuade the next (Rogers, 1962; Moore, 1991).

WHO DEFINED IT ORIGINALLY

Everett M. Rogers established the categories and their proportions in *Diffusion of Innovations* (1962), synthesising 508 diffusion studies across agriculture, medicine and education at Ohio State University. Geoffrey A. Moore (1991) added the discontinuity between early adopters and the early majority, which he named the chasm, from observation of Silicon Valley technology firms.

WHY THIS DEFINITION WAS DEVELOPED

Rogers sought a general theory of why demonstrably superior innovations spread slowly or not at all, having observed the delayed uptake of hybrid seed corn by Iowa farmers. Moore's later addition addressed a specific commercial failure pattern: products that succeeded with visionary buyers and then stalled, because the early majority required references from peers that the early adopters could not supply.

HOW IT IS USED

Identify which adopter group a given internal or external audience belongs to, and match the evidence offered to that group - novelty and advantage for early adopters, peer proof and low switching risk for the early majority.

WHEN IT IS USED

When planning the rollout sequence of an internal AI capability, in go-to-market planning for an AI-enabled product, and in diagnosing why a successful pilot has not spread beyond its original team.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Change managers sequencing internal rollout, product and marketing leaders planning commercial launch, and adoption leads diagnosing stalled deployments.

FIGURE 1 - THE ADOPTER DISTRIBUTION AND THE CHASM

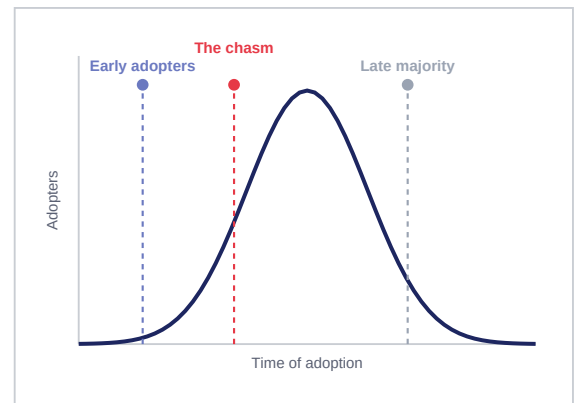


Figure 1. Adoption is approximately normally distributed across the population. Moore's chasm sits between the visionary early adopters and the pragmatic early majority; internal AI rollouts most often stall at exactly this point (after Rogers, 1962; Moore, 1991).

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Before Rogers, adoption was treated as a single aggregate rate to be accelerated by more information. Rogers replaced the aggregate with a segmented population having different decision criteria, which made targeted rather than uniform communication possible. Moore's contribution was to deny that the sequence is continuous: the gap between early adopters and the early majority is a discontinuity requiring a change of strategy, not merely more of the same effort.

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[AI Adoption - Unit 4](#)
[Technology Acceptance Model - Unit 4](#)
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SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

- Moore, G.A. (1991) *Crossing the Chasm: Marketing and Selling High-Tech Products to Mainstream Customers*. New York: HarperBusiness.
- Rogers, E.M. (1962) *Diffusion of Innovations*. New York: Free Press.
- Rogers, E.M. (2003) *Diffusion of Innovations*. 5th edn. New York: Free Press.
- Ryan, B. and Gross, N.C. (1943) 'The diffusion of hybrid seed corn in two Iowa communities', *Rural Sociology*, 8(1), pp. 15-24.